

Royal Mile & Old Town - Kids

UK Family Tour

A City Built on a Volcano's Tail

Edinburgh's Old Town has the best origin story of any city street: it's built on a volcano. Three hundred and fifty million years ago, a volcano erupted here. Its plug of hard black rock became Castle Rock. Then, during the Ice Ages, a giant glacier — ice hundreds of meters thick — ground its way across this land. The hard volcanic rock split the ice like a boulder splits a river, protecting a long tail of softer ground behind it. The result is called a crag and tail: the castle sits on the crag, and the Royal Mile runs straight down the tail, from the castle at the top to Holyrood Palace at the bottom. The city grew along the tail because the sides were too steep — so instead of building outward, Edinburgh built UP. Look at the old tenement buildings, called “lands”: some were ten, twelve, even fourteen stories high, hundreds of years before elevators. These were basically the world's first skyscrapers. Rich and poor lived stacked in the same buildings — fancy folk in the middle floors, the poorest at the very top and very bottom. And all the narrow alleys running off the street? They're called closes and wynds. Each has a name and a story. Down the Mile you go — it's one Scottish mile, slightly longer than a regular one, and all downhill.

Tell Me More: Reading the Old Town Like a Detective

Now that you know the shape of the city, here's how to read it. The closes — those narrow alleys — are numbered in the hundreds along the Mile, and their names are little history files: Fleshmarket Close (the meat market), Anchor Close (a tavern), Advocate's Close (a fancy lawyer lived there). World's End Close marks where the old city wall stood: for the poorest people of Edinburgh, who couldn't afford the toll to re-enter through the gate, the city gate genuinely was the end of their world — many never once left the walled city in their lives. There's a pub called The World's End there today, and brass markers in the road trace where the wall ran. Look up as you walk: the tall old buildings often show their history in layers — fancy carved doorways at the bottom, plainer stone above, and sometimes a date carved over a door from the fifteen or sixteen hundreds. Find the oldest date-stone you can; it's a good competition. Look down too: outside St Giles, brass cobbles spell things, and small plaques everywhere mark where famous people lived, were born, or — this being old Edinburgh — were executed. And one more word for your collection: the city's nickname Auld Reekie means Old Smoky — from the haze of coal smoke that hung over it, visible from far away, so travelers approaching would literally see the reek before the city. Look at today's clean air and consider how far the place has come.

The Rock Detective

Here's a job for your eyes. Stand on the Royal Mile and look for the big green hill that rises up behind the Old Town, like a sleeping lion. That's Arthur's Seat, and it's another old volcano, a cousin of the one under the castle. Beside it is a long reddish cliff called Salisbury Crags. Edinburgh isn't just built on one volcano, it's built in the middle of a whole family of them, all fast asleep for hundreds of millions of years.

Now here's the detective part. A little over two hundred years ago, a curious man named James Hutton used to walk out to those crags and stare at the rock. Everybody in his day believed the Earth was only a

few thousand years old. But Hutton looked closely, the way a detective looks at clues, and he noticed something. Melted rock had squeezed in between the flat layers of older stone, like jam pushed between the pages of a book. For that to happen, the ground must have been squished and heated and folded over and over, incredibly slowly, for a length of time so enormous that a few thousand years was nowhere near enough.

So Hutton did something brave. He looked at these rocks and said the Earth must be almost unimaginably ancient, far older than anyone had ever dared to say. He couldn't put a number on it, but he could tell it was gigantic. He wrote that when he studied the rocks, he could find no sign of a beginning and no sign of an end.

He was right. Today we know the Earth is about four and a half billion years old, and Hutton is called the father of geology, which is the science of rocks and the story they tell. And that giant idea, the idea we now call deep time, was worked out partly by a man staring at a cliff you can see with your own eyes from this very street.

So while you walk the Mile, keep glancing at that green hill and that red cliff. You're not just looking at scenery. You're looking at one of the places where humans first figured out how old our planet really is. Not bad for a lump of old volcano.

Climbing Up a Land

Let's pretend, just for a minute, that you lived here three hundred years ago, in one of those towering buildings called lands. Ready? Here is your ordinary day, and it is a workout.

Your family's home is a single room near the very top, say the ninth floor. There is no lift, of course. To get up and down you use one narrow, twisting stone staircase called a turnpike stair, and every single family in the building shares it. So on your way down you squeeze past the wig-maker, the fishwife, a lawyer in a fine coat, and a family of ten, all using the same worn steps. Rich and poor, bumping shoulders, saying good morning, a whole little town stacked inside one staircase.

Now, you're thirsty. Where's the tap? There isn't one. There's no running water in the building at all. Water comes from a public well down in the street, and hauling it up nine floors is exhausting, so the city has a special job for that. Strong men called water caddies carry heavy barrels of water up the stairs, and you pay them for each delivery. Imagine paying someone just to bring you a bucket, then guarding it carefully because every drop climbed nine floors on someone's back.

Your one room is where the whole family eats, works, and sleeps, all together, lit at night by candles and a smoky fire. And remember, there's no bathroom either, which is where last night's shout of gardyloo comes in.

Here's the part that surprises people. In most cities, the rich lived in one neighbourhood and the poor in another. But in old Edinburgh they lived in the same building, just on different floors. The comfortable middle floors, not too many stairs, not too close to the smelly street, were the fancy ones, where a judge or a merchant might live. The poorest families were squeezed into the damp cellars at the bottom and the freezing attics at the top.

So next time you're grumbling about climbing stairs, picture it. No lift, no tap, a candle in your hand, and a water caddy huffing up behind you with your bath. Look up at those tall old buildings again. Every one of those windows was somebody's whole world.

Gardyloo! The Smelliest City in Europe

Time for the gross part, and it's all true. Old Edinburgh had a big problem: tens of thousands of people packed into tall buildings, and no toilets, no sewers, no drains. So what did people do with their, um, buckets? At ten o'clock each night, they opened the window and threw everything into the street below — first shouting “Gardyloo!”, from the French for “watch out for the water.” Though it was not, mostly, water. If you were walking below, you had one second to shout back “Haud yer haund!” — hold your hand! — and jump. The mess flowed down the sloping streets, and the smell was so legendary that the city's nickname was Auld Reekie — Old Smelly. People walking at night would say the smell was so thick you could tell what floor a family lived on. This is also, some say, why gentlemen walked on the road side of the pavement, protecting the person beside them from splashes from above. And here's a bonus: some say the toilet word “loo” comes from gardyloo itself. Next time an adult on this trip says they're off to the loo, you may inform them they are speaking eighteenth-century Edinburgh sewage slang. You're welcome.

Tell Me More: Doctors, Body Snatchers and the Smell of Progress

The filth of old Edinburgh has a strange silver lining: it helped make this city a world capital of medicine. All that disease meant doctors were desperately needed, and Edinburgh's medical school became the best on Earth — students came from everywhere, including many of America's first doctors. But medical students needed to study real human bodies, and there weren't enough... legally. Enter the body snatchers: gangs who dug up fresh graves at night and sold the bodies to anatomy teachers, no questions asked. Families fought back with iron cages over graves — called mortsafes, you can still see them in Greyfriars Kirkyard — and watchtowers where relatives guarded new graves for weeks. Then, in 1828, two men named Burke and Hare skipped the digging entirely and murdered sixteen people to sell. When they were caught, Burke was hanged before a crowd of twenty-five thousand — and, in the era's idea of justice, his body was publicly dissected and his skeleton put on display at the university, where it remains to this day. A pocketbook was made from his skin; it's in a museum here. Edinburgh does not hide its dark bits. The good news ending: the scandal forced Parliament to change the law so medical schools got bodies legally, the graveyard cages became antiques, and the medical school stayed brilliant — it later produced the discoverer of chloroform anesthesia and the professor whose diagnostic tricks inspired his student Arthur Conan Doyle to invent Sherlock Holmes.

The Street Under the Street

Here is one of the strangest secrets in Edinburgh. Right under your feet, there is a whole street that has been frozen in the sixteen hundreds, buried in the dark, for nearly three hundred years. It's real, and you can go down into it.

It's called Mary King's Close. Long ago it was an ordinary busy alley of tall houses, full of families, shops and merchants. Then, around the seventeen fifties, the city decided to build a big grand building on top, the one that's now the City Chambers. But instead of knocking the old houses all the way down, the builders did something lazy and amazing. They chopped the tops off the buildings and used the lower floors as foundations, sealing the old street underneath like a secret in a drawer.

So it's still down there. Real doorways. Real rooms. Fireplaces where people once cooked. Little windows that now look out onto nothing but darkness and the underside of a modern building. When you visit, it's cold and quiet, and your voice goes strange, and you walk on the actual cobbles that people walked on four hundred years ago, deep beneath the traffic of today.

Now, being Edinburgh, there are spooky stories too, and here's where you get to be careful and clever. The story goes that a little girl called Annie once haunted one of the rooms, sad because she'd lost her doll. Visitors started leaving toys for her, and today one corner is piled with little gifts. It's a sweet story, and the toys are absolutely real, but nobody can actually prove a ghost, so keep that in your detective notebook under "lovely legends," not "facts."

There's a scarier tale too, that sick people were once sealed up alive down there during a plague. That one, happily, isn't true. The records show the city actually sent food and helpers to people who were ill and shut in. So it was grim, but not that cruel.

What's absolutely true, and honestly weirder than any ghost, is the buried street itself. A whole slice of old Edinburgh, tucked underneath the new one, waiting in the dark. As you walk the bright modern Mile, remember, there is another Edinburgh below you, keeping perfectly still.

The Stinky Lake and the Witch Test

You already know that at ten o'clock at night, all the horrible buckets got thrown into the street with a shout of gadyloo. But have you ever wondered where all that mess ended up? Gravity has the answer. It ran downhill.

And at the bottom of the hill, on the north side of the castle, there used to be a lake. It was called the Nor Loch, which just means the North Lake. Once upon a time it had been made on purpose, to help defend the castle, but over the years it turned into the city's giant open drain. Everything the city didn't want slid down into it, so instead of a sparkling blue lake, it became a still, green, evil-smelling soup. People threw in their rubbish, their dead animals, everything. If you can imagine the worst pond in the world, multiply the smell by a hundred, and that was the Nor Loch.

Now brace yourself, because the lake has a dark story too. In those days, people had a cruel and completely wrong idea. If they suspected a woman of being a witch, they would sometimes tie her thumbs to her toes and throw her into the loch. Here was their twisted test. If she floated, they said she was guilty and a witch. If she sank, she was innocent, but of course she might drown. It was a test nobody could really win, and it was terribly unfair. More than three hundred people are thought to have been ducked in that lake. It's one of the sad, shameful things humans used to do when they were frightened and didn't understand the world, and it's important to remember it really happened.

But this story has a genuinely happy ending, and you're going to walk right through it. A couple of hundred years ago, the city finally drained the disgusting lake away. And do you know what they turned that stinking, sorrowful place into? One of the most beautiful parks in Britain, called Princes Street Gardens, green and full of flowers, right below the castle. All the earth and rubble they dug out was piled up into a big ramp called the Mound, which is still there holding a road today.

So remember, when you stroll through those lovely gardens, you're walking over a spot that was once the smelliest, saddest lake in Edinburgh. The city cleaned up its worst place and grew a garden on top. That's a pretty good trick.

Spit on the Heart, Salute the Dog

Two Edinburgh traditions to collect today. First: near St Giles' Cathedral, look down. Set into the cobblestones is a heart shape made of granite blocks — the Heart of Midlothian. It marks the doorway of the Old Tolbooth, the city's dreaded prison, where executions happened outside the door. When the prison was demolished two hundred years ago, locals started spitting on the heart to show what they thought of the place. The tradition stuck — though today people say it's for good luck. So yes: this is the one place on the trip where you are officially allowed to spit in public. Aim for the middle of the heart. Mind your shoes. Second tradition: a short walk from the Royal Mile stands a small statue of a Skye terrier called Greyfriars Bobby. The story goes that when Bobby's owner, a night watchman named John Gray, died in 1858, Bobby refused to leave — he stayed near his master's grave in Greyfriars Kirkyard for fourteen years, becoming the whole city's dog. The Lord Provost himself paid Bobby's dog license so he couldn't be taken away as a stray. Historians argue about the details, but Edinburgh doesn't care: Bobby got a statue, and visitors rub his nose for luck. His nose is shiny gold from a million rubs. Add yours.

Tell Me More: More Street Legends

Three more Royal Mile legends to collect on your walk. One: near the castle end, you'll pass a church spire building called The Hub, and further down, outside a courtroom, a statue of the philosopher David Hume in a toga — one of the smartest humans who ever lived — whose big toe shines gold because students rub it for luck before exams. Philosophers would point out that Hume didn't believe in luck. Students rub it anyway. Two: John Knox House, one of the oldest houses on the Mile, all wooden galleries and painted ceilings — the fiery preacher John Knox may or may not have actually lived there, but the house is nearly five hundred years old and survives because of the legend that he did. Sometimes a good story protects a building better than a law. Three: the Mile's most famous small resident might be Wojtek — a statue in Princes Street Gardens nearby of a full-grown brown bear. Wojtek was a real bear, adopted as a cub by Polish soldiers in World War Two; he was officially enlisted as a soldier — rank: private, later corporal — so he could travel with his unit, learned to carry artillery shells during battle, loved beer and wrestling, and retired to Edinburgh Zoo, where his old army friends visited him and he'd perk up at Polish words. Edinburgh: a city where even the war memorials include a beer-drinking bear.

The Gentleman Burglar

Time to meet the most two-faced man in Edinburgh's history, and I mean that almost literally.

His name was William Brodie, though everyone called him Deacon Brodie, and in the daytime he was as respectable as a person could be. He was a skilled cabinetmaker, which means he built beautiful wooden furniture and cabinets. He was so trusted and important that he became a city councillor, one of the men who helped run Edinburgh, and the head of his group of tradesmen. Fine clothes, good manners, invited to all the best dinners. If you'd met him on the Mile, you'd have tipped your hat and thought, there goes a gentleman.

But here's the twist. At night, Deacon Brodie was a burglar.

And he was a clever one. You see, Brodie's respectable day job was the perfect disguise for his secret night job. Rich families hired him to build their cabinets and fit their locks, which meant he was welcomed right into their homes. While he was there, measuring their furniture and chatting politely, he would quietly press their door keys into a lump of soft wax to make a secret copy. Then, days later, in the dark, he'd let himself in with his copied key and rob them. Nobody suspected the nice Mr Brodie who had just been over for tea.

Why did such a well-off man steal? He had expensive secret habits. He loved gambling, he owed money, and he was secretly keeping two separate families who didn't know about each other. Keeping all those secrets cost a fortune, so he stole to pay for them.

It couldn't last forever. In seventeen eighty-eight one of his robberies went wrong, his gang was caught, and one of them told on him. Deacon Brodie was arrested and hanged, and the whole city was stunned that their trusted councillor had been a thief all along.

But here's the best part for a storyteller. Many years later, an Edinburgh boy named Robert Louis Stevenson grew up hearing about Deacon Brodie, the respectable man with the wicked secret life. That idea, one person hiding two completely different selves, stuck in his imagination. And when he grew up, he wrote one of the most famous scary stories in the world, the tale of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde, about a good man who turns into a monster. So keep an eye out on the Mile for a pub with Brodie's name on it. That double-life burglar became the seed of a monster in a book.

Was Bobby Really Real?

You've rubbed Bobby's shiny nose and heard the story, the loyal little dog who guarded his master's grave for fourteen years. It's a beautiful tale. But a good detective always asks one more question, so let's ask it. How much of the Bobby story is actually true?

The honest answer is, some of it may have grown a bit taller in the telling, and finding that out is its own kind of adventure.

A historian called Jan Bondeson went digging into the old records, the way Hutton dug into rocks, and he noticed some suspicious things. Right next to the churchyard where Bobby lived, there was a café and a graveyard keeper, and a famous, faithful little dog was very good for business. Crowds came to see Bobby, and while they were there, they bought food and paid the keeper. So Bondeson wondered, did those men make Bobby's story a little more perfect than it really was, to keep the visitors coming?

He found something even stranger. Fourteen years is a very long time for a small dog to live. Bondeson thinks the first Bobby may have died partway through, and been quietly swapped for a younger, cuter dog who looked similar. Two dogs, one legend. If that's true, no single dog waited fourteen years at all.

So does that ruin the story? Not really. Here's what we can say for certain. A stray dog really did live around that churchyard. The people of Edinburgh really did love him, so much that the city's leader paid his dog licence himself so nobody could take him away as a stray. And when a wealthy noblewoman had a little statue made in his honour, real crowds came to see it. The dog was real. The love was real. The statue is right there for you to touch.

It's just that some of the exact details, the neat fourteen years, the perfectly loyal single dog, are probably part legend, part true. And that's worth knowing, because it happens with lots of famous stories. People love a tale so much that they polish it, and round off the awkward corners, until it shines brighter than the plain facts ever did.

So go ahead, rub Bobby's golden nose. Just do it like a proper Edinburgh detective, half believing, half wondering, and enjoying the story either way.